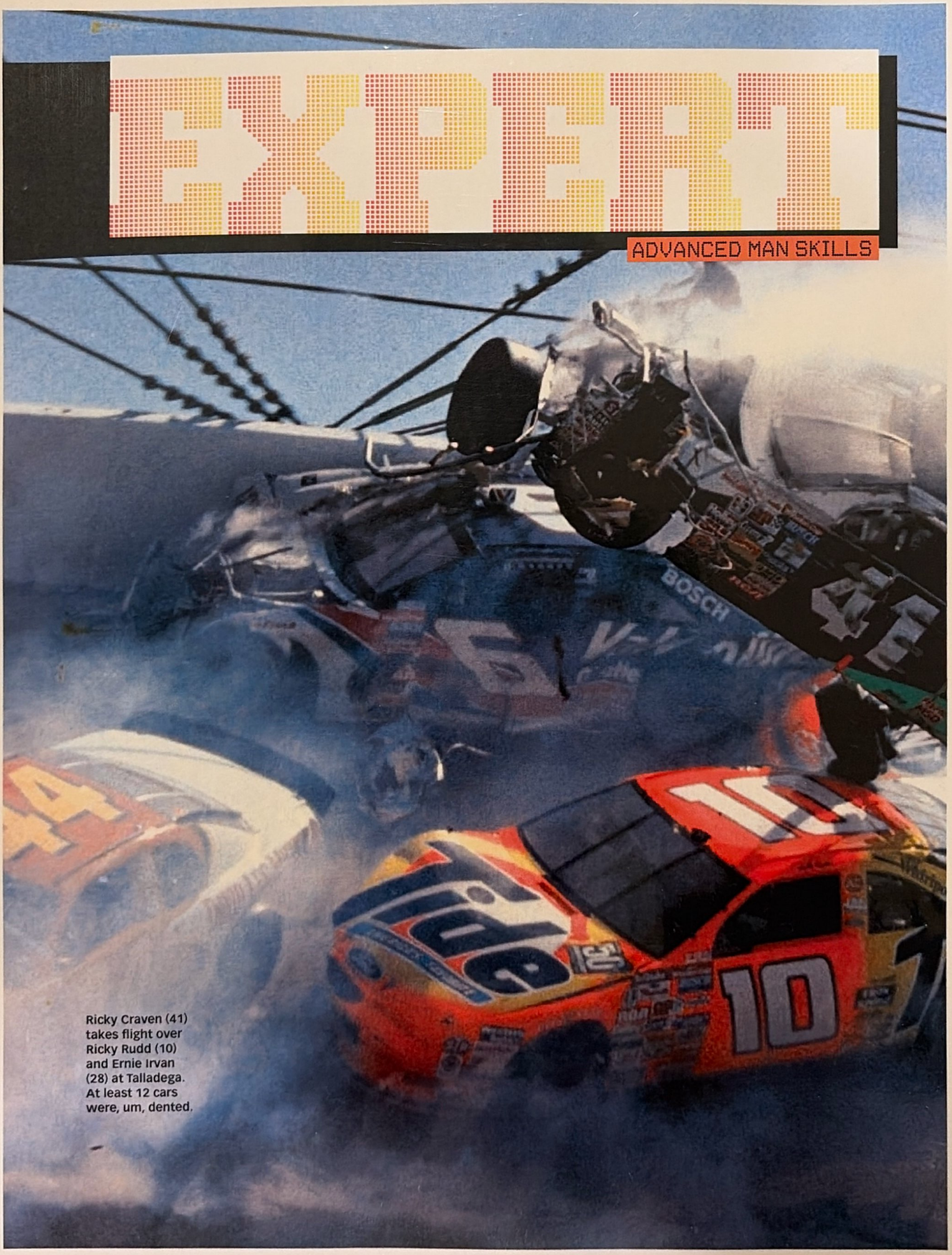
EXPERT

ADVANCED MAN SKILLS



Ricky Craven (41) takes flight over Ricky Rudd (10) and Ernie Irvan (28) at Talladega. At least 12 cars were, um, dented.

DRIVE LIVE

Steering Clear

NASCAR Nextel Cup Series driver Martin Truex Jr. dodges heavy metal carnage for a living. Here's how to avoid interstate pileups and drive like a pro.

Watch Martin drop the hammer at the Dollar General 300 on October 12.

Martin Truex Jr.

1

Sit Up Straight
You can get away with slouching in your neighborhood, but highway driving requires an infinitely more reactive body position. "As a general rule, you need to be able to see the front of your hood," says Truex. "This gives you more spatial awareness for faster reactions." Sit up, pay attention to your surroundings, and cover both pedals with the ball of your foot, not just the tips of your toes.

2

Control the Jerk
Trouble can be lurking behind you as well, so stay acutely aware of the surrounding cars at all times. If you need to swerve, even on a wide-open expressway, less is generally more. "Be gentle with the car and swerve as little as possible," Truex insists. "If you only need to move over two feet, you should barely have to turn the wheel—no need to yank your car across a bunch of lanes." This will help prevent a violent overcorrection after your initial swerve.

3

Hit the Brakes
If you have to shut 'er down in a hurry, try to hold your line. "The most efficient way to slow down is going straight," explains Truex. "If you need to stop quickly in an emergency, the worst thing you can do is jerk the wheel." Apply firm, consistent pressure on the brake (never "stabbing" it down) and keep your eyes hyperfixed on the developing situation in front of you, ready to move left or right if necessary.

4

Brace for Impact
"If you have absolutely no choice but to hit something on the road, you'll want to hit front-first," says Truex. "Go into a spin and you risk a side impact right next to you, where there's less protection." If the object ahead is relatively harmless, you're probably better off hitting it head-on. "Don't kill yourself swerving around a cardboard box swirling in the road," he advises. "Unless it's not just cardboard."

Text: Jeff Foss